to Shah Shooja before he has entered the country,' Wade assured Auckland.[1] But, from the beginning, almost nothing went as planned.

The Simla Manifesto had been explicit that the Shah would return home 'surrounded by his own troops'. The problem was that Shuja at this point had no troops; indeed his only followers were his usual handful of mutilated household servants. So the first thing was to recruit a new army, the Shah Shuja Contingent. Would-be recruits began arriving in Ludhiana throughout the summer of 1838. A few of them were Indian Afghans of Rohilla descent whose ancestors had migrated to the Ganges basin in the eighteenth century, but most of them were local 'Hindoos . . . camp followers from the Company's military stations'. The recruits were so wild and raw, however, and so undisciplined, that it was soon decided that this 'rabble' of 'ragamuffins' were not fit to be put on public parade at the grand ceremonial launch of the expedition at Ferozepur.[2] There was also the issue, as one British officer put it in a letter, that it was clearly a 'fiction [that] the "Shah [was] entering his dominions surrounded by his own troops" when the fact is too notorious to escape detection and exposure, that he has not a single subject or Affghan amongst them'.[3]

So in late August, ahead of the rest of the army, Shuja and his Contingent were quietly marched off out of sight through Ferozepur to Shikarpur, there to begin intensive drilling. Before long, the Contingent had deviated from its intended route, run amok and looted Larkana.[4o] This revived memories across Sindh of the violence and 'great excesses' committed by Shuja's troops on their last promenade up the Indus, rendering the Amirs of Sindh even less willing to help than they had been. To make matters worse, the first Bombay troops arriving by sea at Karachi mistook an artillery salute from the lighthouse for an attack, and reduced to rubble the principal coastal fort of their supposed Sindhi allies.

This was not the only problem. Ominously, the revival of Shuja's fortunes seemed already to have gone to his head. Before long the Shah – whose good nature had clearly been corroded and hardened by his long run of ill-fortune – had fallen out with all his British officers, alienating them with his haughtiness and his insistence on making them remain standing in his presence.[5] He also alarmed his British minders by referring to the Afghans, his future subjects, as 'a pack of dogs, one and all'.[6] 'We must try', noted an exasperated Macnaghten, 'and bring him gradually round to entertain a more favourable view of his subjects.' Meanwhile, Prince Timur had failed